CHAPTER 12

CHALLENGES TO AND RESTORATION OF THE CONGRESS SYSTEM

CHAPTER ESSENCE AT A GLANCE:

Examine the political transition following Jawaharlal Nehru and Lal Bahadur Shastri, the seminal Fourth General Elections of 1967, the phenomenon of non-Congress coalitions (SVD) and political defections ('Aaya Ram Gaya Ram'), the historic 1969 split between Indira Gandhi and the organizational Syndicate over the Presidential election, the abolition of Privy Purses and bank nationalization, and Indira Gandhi's dramatic electoral triumph in 1971 with 'Garibi Hatao'.

4 CORE PRINCIPLES TO UNDERSTAND FIRST

• **The 1967 Political Earthquake:** The Fourth General Election shattered Congress dominance in the states, where it lost power across eight states, unleashing coalition governance (Samyukta Vidhayak Dal) and political defections.

• **Syndicate versus Indira Gandhi Confrontation:** A faction of senior conservative Congress leaders ('the Syndicate', led by K. Kamaraj and S.K. Patil) sought to control Prime Minister Indira Gandhi, prompting her to adopt a radical pro-poor policy stance.

• **The Historic 1969 Congress Split:** Triggered by the Presidential election after Dr. Zakir Hussain's death, Indira Gandhi supported independent candidate V.V. Giri against official Congress nominee Neelam Sanjiva Reddy, calling for a 'conscience vote' and splitting the party into Congress (O) and Congress (R).

• **Electoral Restoration and 'Garibi Hatao':** Indira Gandhi forged a populist left-centrist platform centered on 'Garibi Hatao' (Abolish Poverty), sweeping the 1971 mid-term elections with 352 seats and re-establishing Congress supremacy on a personalist foundation.

ESSENTIAL CONSTITUTIONAL ARTICLES & THEORIES

$$\text{1967 Fourth General Election} \iff \text{'Political Earthquake'} \rightarrow \text{SVD Coalitions} + \text{Defections ('Aaya Ram Gaya Ram')}$$

First Major Electoral Fracture of Congress Dominance

$$\text{Congress Split (1969)} \iff \text{Congress (O) [Syndicate]} \longleftrightarrow \text{Congress (R) [Indira Gandhi and V.V. Giri]}$$

Organizational Cleavage between Conservative Old Guard and Populist Wing

$$\text{Indira Radical Agenda} \iff \{\text{14 Banks Nationalised (1969)}, \quad \text{Privy Purses Abolished}, \quad \text{10-Point Programme}\}$$

Leftward Economic Shift Realigning Electoral Support

$$\text{1971 Landslide Restoration} \iff \text{'Garibi Hatao'} \rightarrow \text{375 Coalition Seats} \rightarrow \text{Restoration of Congress Hegemony}$$

Decisive Reassertion of National Electoral Dominance

CRUCIAL EXAM PRECAUTIONS & VALUATION RUBRIC SECRETS

• **Alert:** Never confuse Congress (O) with Congress (R); Congress (O) stood for Organisation (the Syndicate wing led by Kamaraj), while Congress (R) stood for Requisitionists (Indira Gandhi's wing).

• **Alert:** Remember that the abolition of Privy Purses was initially struck down by the Supreme Court; Indira Gandhi made it a central campaign issue in 1971 and passed the 26th Constitutional Amendment Act in 1971 to abolish it permanently.

• **Alert:** Do not confuse the Grand Alliance of 1971 with the Samyukta Vidhayak Dal of 1967; the Grand Alliance was a national electoral coalition formed by major non-communist, non-Congress parties (SSP, PSP, BJS, Swatantra, and Congress (O)) specifically to defeat Indira Gandhi in 1971.

HIGH-YIELD CENTUM QUESTIONS & STEP-BY-STEP EXPLANATIONS

1. Why were the results of the 1967 Fourth General Election termed a 'Political Earthquake' by political commentators? [Score: 2 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Loss of Dominance:** Congress won only a thin majority in the Lok Sabha with its lowest tally of seats and popular vote share since 1952. **[1 Mark]**

• **Loss of Power in States:** Congress was ousted from power in seven major states and lost government in two others due to defections, breaking its unbroken rule. **[1 Mark]**

2. Explain the expression 'Aaya Ram, Gaya Ram' in the context of Indian politics after 1967. [Score: 2 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Origins:** Coined after Haryana legislator Gaya Lal changed his party affiliation three times in a single fortnight in 1967. **[1 Mark]**

• **Significance:** Became a legendary phrase symbolizing opportunistic political defections by elected legislators switching parties for ministerial posts or money, causing frequent coalition collapses. **[1 Mark]**

3. Who were the 'Syndicate' in the Congress Party? Name two prominent leaders belonging to this group. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Definition:** An informal group of powerful, conservative regional leaders within the Congress who controlled the party organizational machinery in the 1960s. **[1 Mark]**

• **Kingmakers:** Played a decisive role in installing Lal Bahadur Shastri in 1964 and Indira Gandhi in 1966 as Prime Minister, expecting them to be subservient to the party bosses. **[1 Mark]**

• **Two Prominent Leaders:** K. Kamaraj (former Chief Minister of Madras and Congress President) and S.K. Patil (political boss of Bombay). **[1 Mark]**

4. Describe how the 1969 Presidential election triggered the formal split of the Indian National Congress. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Official Nominee versus Indira's Choice:** The Syndicate nominated Lok Sabha Speaker Neelam Sanjiva Reddy as the official candidate, while Indira Gandhi encouraged Vice-President V.V. Giri to contest as an independent. **[1 Mark]**

• **Call for Conscience Vote:** Rejecting the party whip issued by Congress President S. Nijalingappa, Indira Gandhi openly called upon party MPs and MLAs to cast a 'conscience vote'. **[1 Mark]**

• **V.V. Giri's Victory and Formal Split:** V.V. Giri won the presidency; in retaliation, the Syndicate expelled Indira Gandhi from the party, resulting in the split into Congress (O) and Congress (R). **[1 Mark]**

5. Highlight the radical pro-poor policy initiatives undertaken by Indira Gandhi to project a socialist image after 1969. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Nationalization of Commercial Banks:** Promulgated an ordinance nationalizing 14 leading private commercial banks in July 1969 to direct credit toward agriculture and small enterprises. **[1 Mark]**

• **Abolition of Privy Purses:** Terminated the hereditary financial pensions and privileges constitutionally guaranteed to former princely rulers in 1947. **[1 Mark]**

• **Ten-Point Programme:** Pushed through social control of banks, nationalization of general insurance, ceilings on urban property, and public distribution of food grains. **[1 Mark]**

6. Examine the political factors that led to Indira Gandhi's dramatic victory in the 1971 Lok Sabha elections. **[Score: 4 Marks]**

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **'Garibi Hatao' Slogan:** Indira Gandhi gave a positive, unifying socio-economic campaign slogan ('Abolish Poverty'), directly contrasting with the opposition's purely negative slogan of 'Indira Hatao' ('Remove Indira'). **[1 Mark]**

• **New Social Coalition:** Built a solid electoral base comprising landless agricultural labourers, Dalits, Adivasis, minorities, and women, who felt empowered by her socialist policies. **[1 Mark]**

• **Charismatic Mass Appeal:** Campaigned vigorously across the country as a decisive champion of the poor, eclipsing both the Syndicate and regional opposition bosses. **[1 Mark]**

• **Landslide Electoral Mandate:** The Congress (R) and CPI alliance swept 375 seats, completely obliterating the Grand Alliance and restoring one-party dominance on a personalist foundation. **[1 Mark]**

7. How did the restored Congress system under Indira Gandhi differ structurally from the old Congress system of the Nehru era? **[Score: 3 Marks]**

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Personalist Centralization:** The new party depended entirely on the supreme popularity and charisma of Indira Gandhi, unlike the Nehruvian party which had strong independent state leaderships. **[1 Mark]**

• **Erosion of Factional Democracy:** Internal party organizational elections ceased, and factions were suppressed, turning state leaders into appointees dependent on New Delhi's patronage. **[1 Mark]**

• **Weakened Institutional Capacity:** While capable of winning massive electoral mandates, the party lost its grassroots institutional strength and ability to absorb diverse societal tensions. **[1 Mark]**